Between Rescue and Kill

Representations of perception in material origin and how objects interact with their past selves

Master Thesis
Konstfack University of Arts, Craft and Design
Karl Salmonsson



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Karl Salmonsson
Tutor: Peter Andersson
Supervisor of the report: Helen Rix Runting
Examiner: Kristina Fridh

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From El Paso, through Agry Town and Rio Bravo, coming up to Sweetwater, before landing in The Alamo. This is a story about material blending into fiction. This is a story told through objects, about cowhide and gunslingers. It is about creating a spaghetti furniture universe.

Cowhide is here a starting point to examine the fictional life of the cowboy. Coming to the rescue or shooting to kill is not opposites in this work, but a way of having this conversation about emotions for material.

Coming in to this project I started with this idea about a grand method of work. The material would be crucial and at the same time secondary. This method would be able to spin around and around with no regard to the matter at hand.

I called it *Diagram of Workflow*.

I said to myself - This is very smart. You have a material in front of you, the diagram (if followed correctly) gives you ideas and inspiration from aspects of said material. And you design something from that with the only real rule to be that you apply the original material on that designed object. Let us just say that this was the entry to the Western town. And why everything is about different objects with cow hide applied to a degree that could be seen as obsession.

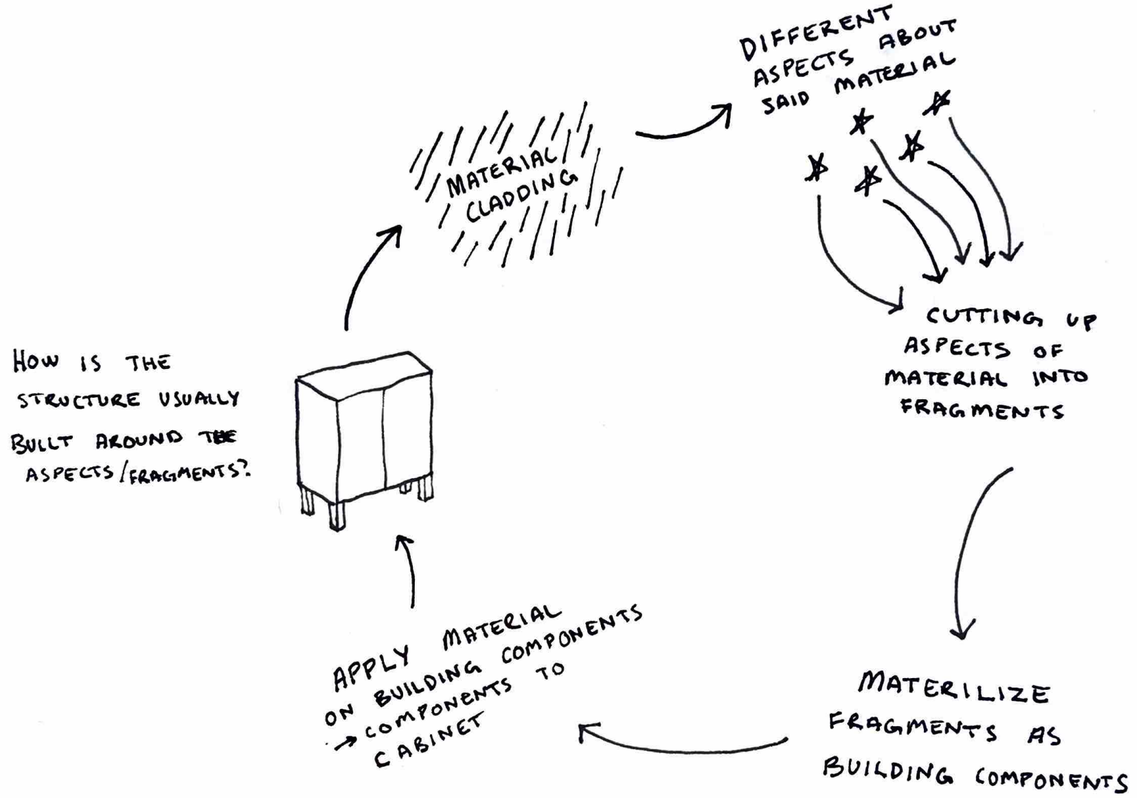


Figure 1: Diagram of workflow. Looping from cabinet to cabinet (Salmonsson, 2026).

The Idea of Work:

Being an architect means to create and explain things that have not yet come to be. For me this is the basic understanding of our work and what we do. To expand on that idea, the work can have different appearances. The model is one. The drawing of course, plan and section combined to visualize the object before it is materialized. Text is often present to specify material, or in technical drawings you can use a hatch that correlates to certain material. All this is to as accurately as possible translate your idea for to others and make them understand, to make a client happy with bold ideas, or a carpenter satisfied with them knowing they will do what is expected. These are all different aspects of explaining and all these models and drawings look and work different to each other. Their appearance is decided by their purpose.

The architect not only explains the exact dimensions or material used to make an object complete. Before the making our ideas must be made up. Some restrictions can be in place, such as a wish from clients, the size of a site or how it is possible to let us bend a material but it is still the process of making stuff up and working for such a time that this actually becomes real. All the hours throughout different design schools and later projects teaches you to make stuff up quicker and more precisely, as one would expect, the more you do it - the easier it gets. Let us not get too carried away and making up stuff just yet. Because in between the idea and the drawing is something more. This is where I would say that the actual work takes place, an idea is just that and a drawing of something bad will never be good.

For the sake of the craft, I must admit that the work of an architect is not as simple as making something up and later draw it on paper. It is much more and much worse, between the ecstasy of success to the self-dough of everything falling apart but let us not go into that. Let us instead continue talking about the role of the architect. To realize the idea, we need something more that the precise: we need to master the ability of being vague. To let someone else fill in the space between what we are stating and what we are thinking. We need to represent the idea of the idea.

Representation is the ultimate tool and weapon of the architect. It can be as clear as a drawing and as lofty as a collage of materials put together to form abstract unity. Working with representation enables one to put the idea in perspective to other aspects of design; material, atmosphere, shape, time, user, prejudice, tactility... As you use representation it will become more complex in what to do or how to use it effectively, since all mentioned could be some form of representation. In this way it will be increasingly more important to know what you want to be showing. The work can be quick simple, composed of your thoughts, and showing a broader picture of the subject. With your representation it is possible to merge your idea with the aspects that would make it real. Using representation for your architectural purposes means combining the different aspects of your work into larger and more expressive figures and compilations. This is why it is a powerful tool, for it is simple yet effective in displaying multiple aspects at once. A drawing can be showing exact dimensions, while it is used layered with pictures showing the material and colors of a site. This can also be seen as showing the time aspect of the site since the pictures were taken at a specific point in time. A model showing the overlaying floor plans and spatial configuration, can be made to house a lightning device focusing on the atmosphere and movement throughout a day.

Coming to this project the material in this scenario reflects these ideas about representation. How to contextualize the idea of an idea. This is not a material exploration in the sense that the material matter is important. What is important is the connotations of the material and how we perceive different aspects of it.

Contextualizing these thoughts have formed the main part of the work. And therefore, the material in itself does not affect the outcome. This has not been an material exploration of how to use a material in new fashion, or how to change one's ideas of what is possible with said material. It has been about the intellectual properties that conforms with our notions.

It is not true that the material did not matter. To have had this project about a material means that it was a material with some qualities. It was also a material strongly connected to furniture. It is important that people see this material as ordinary for the subject, but still be strongly opinionated in different point of views.

The idea of ideas, into ideas about furniture; for furniture. Starting with the object and deciding for material has been the beginning, with the exploration layering with the opinions and prejudice of people about said material. Using humor and wordplay I started to investigate and illustrate these thoughts in the material itself. Being open with the outcome but still formulate a recipe for my work to enlighten the viewer of these symbols.

The Phase I:

The Material:

Cowhide, different colors, with hair.

The objects produced in this Master thesis project in Spatial Design has been representations of an aspect closely linked to the thought we have about the material. This is the basic principle of my thesis work. Cowhide acted as the narrator between ways of looking at material and what we as observers around the objects feel and read into the work.

In this work, the material existed before the formulated idea. These hides appeared before me during a visit to a manufacturer some years ago. They work with material for furniture production and these hides were part of their material waste. Having strong and mixed feelings about the material - I bought it - for next to nothing.

I do not know if I put it on a pedestal, telling myself it was too precious to use, or if there was anything else keeping me from using it. But it remained in my studio and moved with me here to Konstfack. And now, the time had come - to do some work surrounding these hides.

When looking at this material, I want to put my work in between the material and the thought. Cowhide has both the presence of strong materiality and is related to strong cogitations. The material is the representation of life, you can see the hide and understand that it is from something living. But it is not living. The opposite of that, this is material that means death. This project will be affected on the fact that the living and the dead is both part of it.

Working with cowhide is a thought about material identity and the role of material in our time. There are not many materials composed of so different opinions. It can be seen through many different eyes and with those different approaches one can also form endless continuities.



Figure 2: Material testing, cowhide on beech, cowhide on MDF, cowhide on plywood (Salmonsson, 2026).

The Aspect:



Figure 3: The "Man with No Name", in San Miguel, close to the Mexican border. The saloon visible in the far. *A Fistful of Dollars* (Leone, 1964).

This chapter is about me trying to explain the way into this work. We have established the presence of the material, and how it came to be. The cowhide in itself may be enough for a project to explore. The very ins and outs of a material that is related to both the past and present of cladding and furniture making.

However, for this work we have also established that this is not a material exploration. The focus has not been on the materiality or the possibilities within the material. To push this work forward I started with the idea of the material. For some work you would need to have background and knowledge of the material to fully understand it. For this project I wanted to work with the basic notions instead and not know what to expect from the outcome.

Illustrating this is the diagram of workflow, created to have the work centered around the material without crashing into the material properties.

Cowhide and if we broaden the scoop to cow in general, have several different connotations. Much depending on your own relationship and past encounters with the subject. For a cine-file it can be rooted in a love for spaghetti westerns and related to cowboys herding their animals before something gruesome happens. For the vegan it can be much more about an industry that abuse both animal and the environment. For the millennial growing up i rural Sweden a strong reference can be the carton with the Arla cow, that we remember from the milk machines in middle school. For the farmer it is perhaps everything that revolves around the herd of cows. Giving both work and purpose.

All these aspects are relatable in different scenarios and not everyone feels the same. The material is open to conflict and opposing views. This is important for the work, to be able to shift focus between different stands and to use them to make a point. All objects has been heavily influenced by aspects of these views. The material will have to carry these voices and to be able to reflect its own appearance.

To prove one notion, I blended that object with the material and that idea into a morphed concept. My work needs to represent the notion by having it represented in a physical form. Within the objects I want to tell the story about the material with the material as a strong actor. It is the guide for telling the viewer about itself.

Finding the representations of this aspect was a crucial part of this project. Between history, pop culture, everyday life, and so on. I searched by thinking of people in general but also specific ideas or events if it can be reflected in one or more objects.

Looking for this theme or concept have been much about finding a suitable counterpart for the material. In Sweden, there is long tradition in working with hides, but I did not want this project to be about traditional methods or material properties. The Western town, and the Spaghetti Western works well to balance this project between the material and the story, to find the way between the real material and the fictional idea.



Figure 4: In *Stagecoach* (1939), John Wayne portraying "Ringo Kid", displaying the different attributes of Western life. *Stagecoach* (Ford, 1939)

The Story:



Figure 5: Leonardo DiCaprio as Rick Dalton, playing Day Pardee on semi-fictional TV-show *Lancer. Once Upon a Time in Hollywood (Tarantino, 2019).*

Becoming not only the designer, but I will also think of myself the director. And the pieces I make will be the actors of chapters, that combined becomes the film that this project represent. Writing will be the opening move, to see the story unfold itself. Drawing the guides for each individual iteration and following the diagram of the workflow. Telling the background to the object will not only help solidify its though to the material. It will set the framework for the design of the object. Drawings and sketches will set measurement and shape the configuration of form.

This story will be influenced by pop culture in some extent. Not only the way this story will unfold or what this inspiration will be but also in the way that it is told. First, I think of the depictions of fictional western life. I say fictional to not confuse this with the reality that was much different. Hollywood have been telling the story about the late 19th century America for a long time. The pictures may not show the true life or events, often looking away from the treatment of native people. As Michael Valdez Moses puts it in *Savage Nations: Native Americans and the Western* "It is a commonplace of contemporary film criticism that Native Americans have historically been ill served by the American western, a genre in which they have been misrepresented and demeaned. For those who regard an honest and impartial portrayal of historically oppressed minorities as a moral if not an aesthetic imperative, the American western will offer little in the way of spiritual uplift" (Valdez Moses, 2010 pp. 281) The scenes of the western film show a life from a White perspective. The White male can be seen as a hero from a savior perspective or a villain with strong attributes, with little regard to how its depicter Hispanic, Black or Indigenous people. This work is not about the scenes or the story in that sense. The inspiration to this work is found in the architectural language and sets that are foundations in the making of these types of pictures. Even thou the storytelling is fictional, the place and setting is real.



Figure 6:The saloon that represents the set of *Lancer,* in Quentin Tarantino's *Once Upon a Time in Hollywood (Tarantino, 2019).*

Coming into the making of film, one example that fits into this narrative is Quentin Tarantino 's *Once Upon a Time in Hollywood* (Tarantino, 2019). Its depicter Rick Dalton, played by Leonardo DiCaprio, who is an aging actor in the quickly changing landscape of Hollywood. Being an actor that is playing an actor that acts on set is in a way how I want my project to be experienced. In these levels or transitions between real and fictional you can get a crookedness that makes it something more. When we watch the film, we can see Leonardo DiCaprio playing a character, but when he is later seen in costume playing a villain on the show Lancer who is it that we see acting? If we add another level to this, we must take in consideration that Lancer is not made up for this but a real production that aired between 1968-1970. So, is the actor here acting an actor that is acting a person that is acting a character? It may be that my work will not be this difficult to keep up with but for the work to have this substantial base of being referenced to itself and the material that it is made of I must be able to take it all the way. The steps in between the real and the fictional can be made back and forth. Showing the work as an actor in this scene that I am creating, and the scene also being able to be a level in this sequence.

Each object has a storyline that works as this first narrative. This was a foundation for construction as well a first drawing for the appearance. The objects will be representations of these stories. As an architectural practice we can align this work to how you would normally present an architectural project. However, as a result this project has not been seen as just architecture or just furniture. These objects will be put together and act as scenes that will create a longer narrative. Here the stories have overlapped and found a new beginning and end. A installation during the spring exhibition was this representation of another, longer, narrative. The installation was created in a way to support multiple stories, all fitting the narrative of the Western town. See *The Stage: The Shootout: Between Rescue and Kill* for the result of these stories colliding into the larger narrative.

The Architecture:

For this project to have be influenced by the tectonics of the western town, or the western life, I needed key parts of these object to transition from furniture to building and back again. The element of the western town has been fundamental in this search for the spaghetti western furniture.

Different shapes and configurations are closely linked to the Western town. It is not uncommon to have some idea of what this looks like. In *The Western Town - A Theory of Aggregation* - we can follow these stories connected to the spatial setting. Lehnerer et al., write

> The Western town recommends itself as a case study for urban research exactly because it has become a cliche, a seemingly shallow representation of urbanity. Even those who have not watched Western movies are familiar with these towns and there basic organization and feel; in that sense, almost everyone has visited one . ... In a storical project, history does not dictate the outcome of urban form; rather, it becomes the flexible structure behind the scene (in a sense, an appealing reconceptualization of infrastructure) ... Layered into and between narratives, their historical facts do not play out chronologically or continuously, and hardly ever reveal them self in full. Yet the Western town is always a credible setting. Its deliberate arrangement allows new relationships and outcomes to emerge while retaining the town's fundamental recognizability, and therefore its sense of reality. It makes clear a design process whereby reality (history) becomes fiction (narrative) and then, somehow, loops back to a new constructed reality (Lehnerer et al., 2013 p.17).

Continue on this line of thought I could assume some parts of the Western aesthetics's to be of general knowledge. This helped me to set the boundaries for what was necessary in the final spatial setting. More over this assumption over knowledge about the symbols in Western aesthetics's formed an framework for shapes and functions in the objects created. For instance the saloon, with the doors rocking back and forth, were we can assume it do not need to be over explained. The shape of the doors instantly connects your thoughts about the project to the Western setting. The work was to later put that into the setting of the street and town. We must remember that this project is not based on specific stories or parts of the Western fiction but to be a representation of a broader narrative. I must also, if we continue with the doors of the saloon as an example, accept that not all will see the shape or the movement and understand the underlaying mechanics of the project. My intention have therefore been to use a large enough number of symbols to make sure that the Western town is present.

The Western town is not only based of appearance but has a strong urban planning. The reconstructible main street must be part of the success in Hollywood's way of displaying the Western town.

When reading *Learning form Las Vegas* we indulge in Robert Venturi, Denise Scott Brown, and Steven Izenour description of the strip as following:

> The Strip by day is a different place, no longer Byzantine. The forms of the buildings are visible but remain secondary to the signs in visual impact and symbolic content. The space of urban sprawl is not enclosed and directed as in traditional cities. Rather, it is open and indeterminate, identified by points in space and patterns on the ground; these are two-dimensional or sculptural symbols in space rather than buildings in space, complex configurations that are graphic or representational. Acting as symbols, the signs and buildings identify the space by their location and direction, and space is further defined and directed by utility poles and street and parking patterns. In residential sprawl the orientation of houses toward the street, their stylistic treatment as decorated sheds, and their landscaping and lawn fixtures - wagon wheels, mailboxes on erect chains, colonial lamps, and segments of split-rail fences - substitute for the signs of commercial sprawl as the definers of space (Venturi, Scott Brown

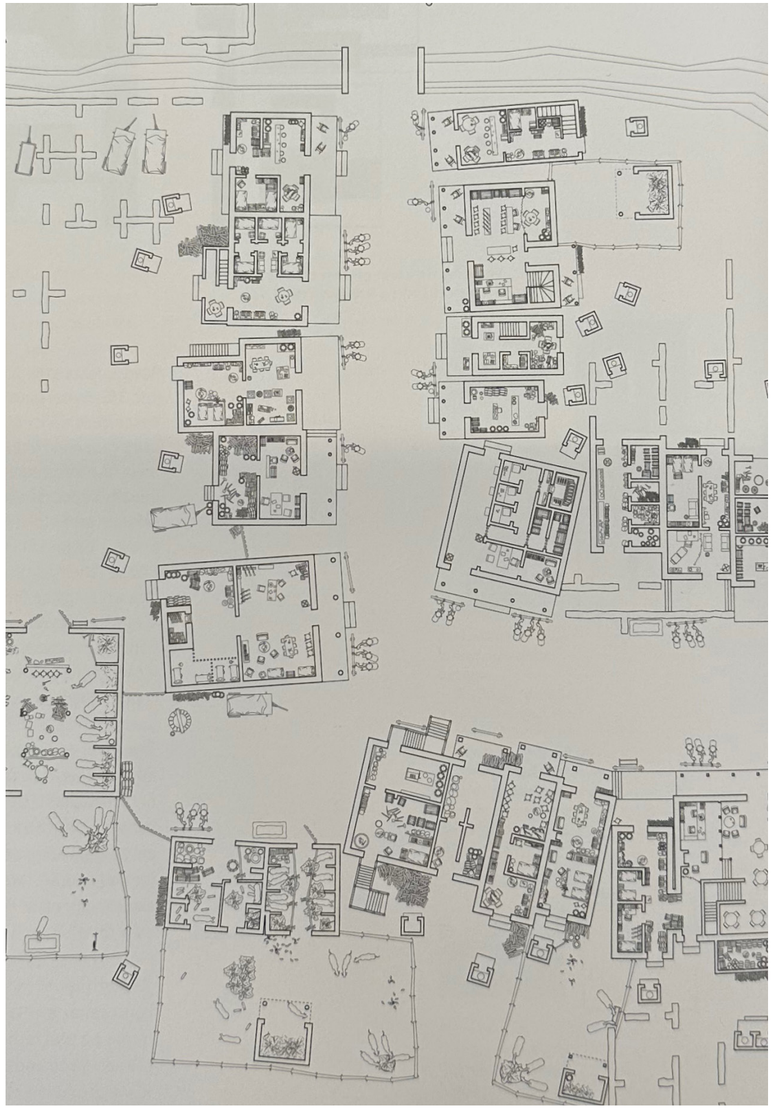


Figure 7: The Western Town is built upon the main (often only) street. Rio Bravo as seen in the picture with the same name (Lehnerer et al., 2013).



Figure 8: This representation is not only showing the indifferences to the ground plane but also the front based architecture (Lehnerer et al., 2013).

and Izenour, 1972, p.81).

Venturi, Scott Brown, and Izenour are in the text comparing *the Strip* with *The Forum*, one could say the most famous of streets in all of America, perhaps the world, with on of the most famous urban sites in architectural history, one being the main street of Las Vegas with all its glory and decadence, and the other being The Forum Romanum, the main square and market place of ancient Rome. Rome being the more present historical reference for the typical symbolism of Las Vegas and the hotel business there, if we acknowledge the strong presence of Caesar's Palace and alike. Venturi, Scott Brown, and Izenour continue the comparison

> Like the complex architectural accumulations of the Roman Forum, the Strip by day reads as chaos if you perceive only its forms and exclude its symbolic content. The Forum, like the Strip, was a landscape of symbols with layers of meaning evident in the location of roads and buildings, buildings representing earlier buildings, and the sculpture piled all over. Formally the Forum was an awful mess; Symbolically it was a rich mix.
>
> The series of triumphal arches in Rome is a prototype of the billboard (mutatis mutandis for scale, speed, and content). The architectural ornament, including pilasters, pediments and coffers, is a kind of bas-relief that makes only gesture toward architectural form. It is as symbolic as the bas-reliefs of processions and the inscriptions that compete for the surface. Along with their function as billboards carrying messages, the triumphal arches in the Roman Forum were spatial markers channeling processional paths within a complex urban landscape. On Route 66 the billboards, set in series at a constant angle towards the oncoming traffic, with a standard distance between themselves and from the roadside, perform a formal-spatial function (Venturi, Scott Brown and Izenour, 1972, p.81)

I should point out as well that my argument here is influenced by the presence of daylight, since the modern street is much different now than from before artificial lightning. Now to the point I want to make in comparing the Western town with this description of the Strip, and thus the Forum Romanum, with the help of Venturi, Scott Brown, and Izenour; these town are not only living quarters for a town resident, but marketplaces for food, lodging, entertainment, post offices, alcohol, medicine, guns and ammunition, and so on, with the strong presence of marketing in the architectural configuration of both town and house. The description of the Strip with buildings present but overladed in signs and symbolic content is easily transferred to the Western town context. The Western town can be described with a mutual typology of both the urban landscape (though calling it landscape can be a bit much) and the building tectonics, where buildings tend to have the same appearance no matter the town or placement with in the urban figuration. When inspecting the Western town we find that the buildings are formed around, often, one central street. This is with the likeness to Las Vegas, where the Strip may not be the only street, not even the largest or the most important street for the city, but still could be argued to be *the street*, where the town (or city) is formed by the buildings placement but equally by the buildings purpose. As for the Western town, alike with the Strip, the purpose of commerce is what defines both street and town (city) and by doing so reflects back to the building and how the building is constructed, with the importance of the building as a sign for its specific purpose within the town (city) and street. Described in *The Western Town - A Theory of Aggregation,* Lehnerer et al., depicts these fronts of the town "... But if the fronts are orchestrated to work together, differing only in the application of the decorative details that speak to each building's particular personality and public role, the buildings' 'backs' are not necessarily obligated to do the same" (Lehnerer et al., 2013 pp.28). To some extent this can establish the Western town, together with the Strip and the Forum Romanum as architecture designed to function with in the boundaries of commerce, were the design is focusing on the inherited symbolism of the buildings own purpose and how to display it as clear as possible for the residents of said town. More so when we in the examine the nomadic life of the fictional cowboy moving from one town to another, or the thrill seeking, bachelor party attending, Las Vegas visitor where every building and location are presenting and competing for the confirmation of the visitor.

These buildings are not only creating this turmoil of advertisement and allurement, but are, with the configuration of the front based building, creating the situation of one building being next to the other, and in such a way creating one long street. This points to the Strip, and Las Vegas, being one kind of heir to the Western town, and the desert setting to fitting for that speculation. And in the same way it is possible to speculate that the Western town is not its own typology but a long line of commerce oriented urban experiments dating back to the Roman empire and the many Forums within that era, going forward to the resemblance in today's failed experiment of the American shopping mall, the holy grail of commerce (Rowan, 2026).

The Phase II:

The Saloon:

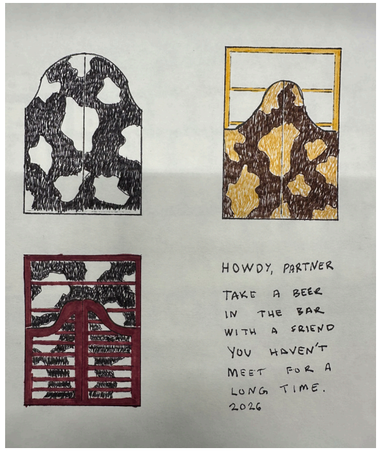


Figure 9: Early sketch of the saloon as a bar cabinet (Salmonsson, 2026).

Howdy, Partner: Take a Beer at the Bar with Your Friend That You Haven't Seen for a Long Time

This scenario is classic: the old school western films portray the villain riding into town. After looking around, the rider jumps of their horse, to slowly tie the reins on the horse stock. Moving quietly, with only the clinging of the spurs sounding to the beat of the steps. The dark clothed figure moving inside, not showing their face before sitting down. The bar is silent. Only the saloon doors moving back and forth. Back and forth. This cabinet is influence by the idea of the saloon.

Coming from architecture this cabinet feels right at home. Looking at the object as a container, you have a strong connection to the work of architecture. As this object "contains", so does the work of architects. When setting the tone for this object, there are certain elements that also is compared. Shelf and floor are both for placing items of some sort. The walls are similar in setting the boundaries for the object. The top is for most parts present in furniture, as well as in architecture. As a last building stone of both cabinet and building we can see the door as a crucial function of design. Not many elements from the Western town are as iconic as the saloon doors. The swinging and sound is both recognizable from a number of spaghetti western pictures. As *Lehnerer et al.*, suggest in *The Western Town, A Theory of Aggregation* the saloon is central to how we perceive how we interact with the Western town.

> As eccentric features go, the saloon is one of the best known in the Western town. Historically it provided entertainment and revenue to settlements, making them not just places but destinations. Dusty one-horse town settlements were transformed into gritty, bustling canyons of debauchery and violence. Ultimately, what made the town successful was also what made it a dangerous place to visit, live in, or pass through. Knowing how to negotiate a saloon could mean the difference between leaving on a horse and leaving in a coffin (Lehnerer et al., 2013 p.98).

Seeing the saloon as equally a safe haven or a place to stumble upon danger fits in to this narrative of my material. The cowhide plays on this ambiguous feeling, where both the natural and the morbid exist. Using the hide as cladding within this object becomes an act of continuing this story of the Western town. Having this scenario as a guide helps me steer the design on to that direction. Becoming the saloon, and becoming this ambiguous object.

We have also established that the Western town, as both a function and a references in films are highly made up. The realness has to be set in relation to what it is suppose to represent. Working with this object of the saloon must also be set into does terms. Is this a representation of the saloon or the built prop for the shoot? This object is not trying to mimic the existing or to be as an accurate copy of specifics. It is a representation of the atmosphere of the saloon.

My starting point in this was to find fragments of the saloon to highlight. We have mentioned some, as the doors swinging back and forth. They are hard to see past and a central part of the idea of the saloon. Analyzing the doors, they have several parts that sets them apart. Both being a pair with the clear symmetry, and not covering the full area of the frame. They are also linked to this movement, and the sound that it creates. For it all to work, these doors must work as they should. Cabinet doors move one way, creating this stop in one direction, as it is not possible to have doors going inwards and still have shelfs working as the purpose of a cabinet. For my object it is equally important to have the display

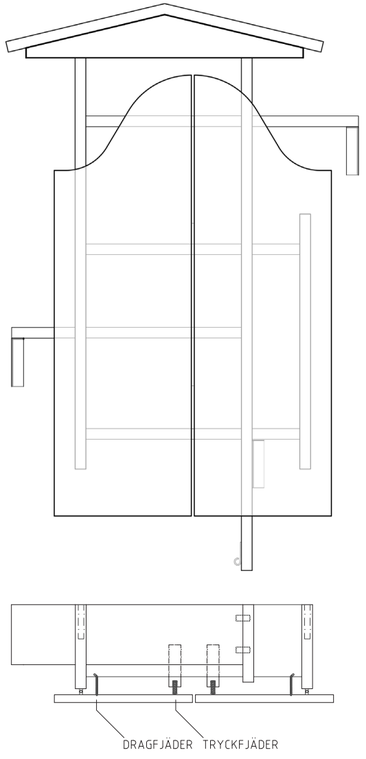


Figure 10: Drawing of cabinet based on the idea of front based architecture (Salmonsson, 2026).

of the doors work in the same way as a saloon door, as it is important to match the function of a cabinet. Remembering the backed fronts of the Western town, the "in-behind" can be different to the visual appearance. However, when construction a saloon door solution, all are expecting a saloon in the "in-behind"; as for the cabinet, the front is the deciding party, equally connected to the design, as to the advertisement of it's self deciding purpose.

Zooming out from the saloon, we find its presence often linked to the central part of the Western town. On can think of the Forum Romanum, all life revolved around this place, and its connection to ones survival, being the center of the Roman city. Its placement in the towns layout works well with the though of never seeing your location from above. Something we can never relate to given our accessibility to both satellite images, and possibilities to even have your own drone flying above

you. The front is therefore a much more active element, and with this notion also a much more important part of the building. Reading more in *The Western Town, A Theory of Aggregation* can help understand this when Lehnerer et al write "To that end, the Western town's fronts can act as false fronts, hiding a back that operates independently and has an architectural identity all its own... Backed fronts are both individual and collective, surface and mass, different and same, object and texture" (Lehnerer et al., 2013, p.28). With this meaning that the Western building is made up from this idea of two parts acting together. The front being displayed while the back operates for purpose and to establish the front central to the street.

More than how the front looks, the texts speak about this disorder between the fractions of buildings in the Western town. Almost as one would be able to shift these fronts and toss them around between the different backrooms and functions. The characteristics of the front is not specific for a pharmacy or a barber, but supported by elements connected to said function. Two fronts can have the same ruff shape and dimensions, however, being set apart by symbols such as the saloon door; saying this, the self-construction of the Western town hardly leaves two buildings being the same shape or size. This lack of programing can be found in the Western town, as well within the saloon: where the space is to be both welcoming and haunting. The configuration of the space is allowing multiple outcomes from the life within, not knowing what comes next.

Establishing the importance of the saloon door, both for the recognition and for the function of a cabinet door, I felt that this part of the piece had be the most connected to the cowhide. Still being central to the work the hides is elevated to a position of some importance. Also the concept of the front and back supports the idea of having the hide in a frontal position. As for the shape of the door, I could easily work from the intuition we have, knowing the shape in elevation, the saloon doors facing each other is elementary.

While thinking so much of the Western town, I wanted to get the perspective of the street when opening the doors. The slightly offset lines between roof and door is too mimic a perspective view of the building. It is hard not to contradict yourself while working with intuition and maybe I wanted this Western town to be adored. Not the cabinet itself but this idea of the architecture. Here I did not follow the geometry of the fictional reality but instead crowned this object, the roof standing above the rest, with the clear imagery of the Greek temple.

The main objective with this cabinet was still to get the sense of it working as a saloon would do. With this in mind, the front's design set to some extent, the most important part was the doors swinging back and forth. Their function within the project was difficult to see past and a central part of the idea of the saloon. The solution for this was using springs for the movement of the doors, one part pushing, while the other pulling; creating this motion back and forth, slowly dying of while creating the signature sound of that happening. As seen in the drawing, the doors are placed to cover the frame, enabling the doors to move around the frame and go past, inwards, to hit the compression springs pushing it out. When sending the door out again the tension springs loads in force and drags it back, starting the process all over again, until the force has slowly died off, and turned the movement back into the front-ended architectural object.



Figure 11: This cabinet must represent the saloon with its content. The saloon is a type of bar but the programing of the space is still unclear enough to fit other activities. The shelf system here goes outside of the frame, and multiple different things can be stored. The only designated shelf is the one for Bulleit Bourbon "Frontier Whiskey"(Salmonsson, 2026).

The Chaps:

Saving the Good Jeans for Church on Sunday

This project is not only about architecture. It is about a fictional life within the boundaries of the Western town. Were the cowhide works as accelerator in the narrative. The story moves forward from the set to the actor, moving between the opportunity and risk. The first iteration went from the perspective of the building and moved into the furniture. Where the cowhide was placed as a symbol or a metaphor as the *material of the west* placed on the most well known detail of *the west*. This iteration revolved more around a part of the Western town that is relating to the cowhide. Here I asked myself the question: where would we see the hide and how would it act within the boundaries of the theme?

One of the more iconic looks from the cinematic universe of the Western town is the horse riding chaps dresser. Here we find a garment that is rooted in the actual world but equally transmits strongly through the camera. In today's popular culture we can see trends and stars also embracing this garment, from the screen and the rise of strong, silent cowboy Rip Wheeler in *Yellowstone* (Yellowstone, 2022) to a whole album by Beyoncé addressing this lifestyle and look with the album *Cowboy Carter* (Beyoncé, 2024). Coming from this idea of the chaps, I wanted to make this object to be a clear representation of this way of wearing hides. Having this protective layer in the front and being able to translate the shape into a merged human-like shape.

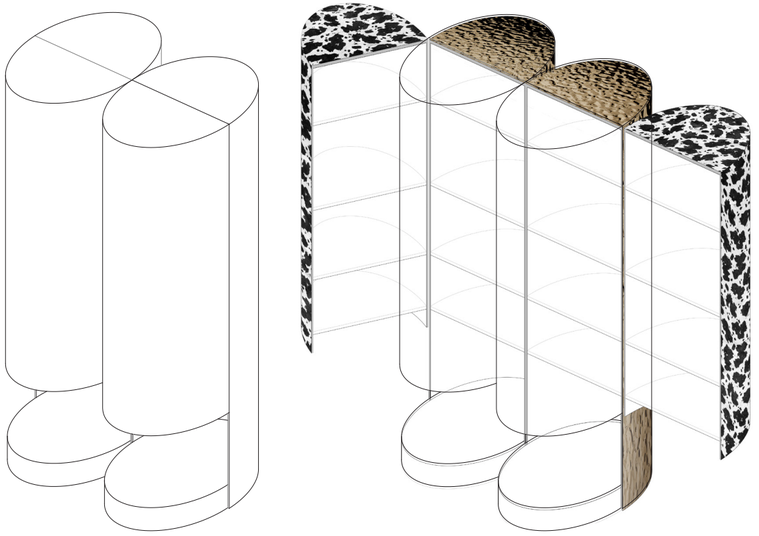


Figure 12: Isometric view of fi st material sketch. In the beginning i thought of having the cabinet being the same sizes as myself, channeling my inner cowboy. To better fit with this ever intertwining of real and fictional this cabinet instead became 1,5:1: the forbidden scale. It is still small enough to have the notion of a human scale, but one that would be the biggest human you would ever seen (Salmonsson,2026).

This scenario is maybe not as fictional, here we can rest i reality and still keep to the boundaries of the Western town; the stranger, the kid, the man with no name, there are many nicknames for the characters that play out these stories. Just as with the doors of the saloon, we all have a nation of how they are dressed. This is a scenario based on reality - played out in numerous - spatial - fictional settings. Wearing chaps is not actually related to saving your jeans for church. It is simple painful to not be wearing them, riding through bushes and the outer parts of the west.

This iteration revolves more around a part of the Western town that is relating to the cowhide. Here I asked myself the question: where would we see the hide and how would it act within the boundaries of the theme? Moving away from my original idea of the diagram of workflow - and embracing the idea of working with intuition.

When choosing to move away from the architecture of the Western town and continue this project by closing in on the garment instead, I did not completely abandon the idea of using the cowhide as cladding on an object that resemble the subject in question. Here we zoom in on to the garment, *still knowing* that the garment is to be worn on the lower part of the body, often covering just the front part of the legs. So in order to make sense of this change in choice of path it was important to find the shape similarly close to the original look, as with the saloon one could say atmosphere instead of look, even if that do not translate so well onto pants-wearing. The atmosphere could be fairly hard to pinpoint as one, when the chaps is both an almost costume-like dress up, and at the same time a working garment, used just as a doctor that puts on the scrubs before going into surgery.

Just as the project balances between the fictional and the real, so will this object dance in between being a crude pastiche of the stranger within *the spaghetti western* and a salute to the working

herder's working today that struggles to do the job that is required. The main focus has been connecting this project to the fictional displayed in the real-based setting. This has played a part in designing these chaps and legs, moving towards something fake, in order to display them as real.

Much more than with the saloon, we can see the presence of other material. The saloon was wood, beech - which is a sturdy type - fitting to the theme, and the cowhide in clear view. Now the beech is continuing to be present and a neutral middle between the materials, which is cowhide and copper. For this cabinet I wanted to make it clear that the cladding is like chaps put on, and the construction follows this in doors being the front half of the cabinet. In that way the doors are clad with the cowhide, still putting them in the center, and in doing so it is comparable to taking them of while opening the cabinet.



Figure 13: This pattern is printed on cowhide. Someone is representing the cowhide on the cowhide, with me working with the cowhide as a representation of your thought on cowhide (Salmonsson, 2026).

While the cowhide is covering the front, the doors are not the same height as the cabinet in whole. They are matching at the top but still leaving space at the bottom, for having this concept, the chaps is strongly connected to the idea of working boots sticking out underneath. Beech is forming both feet, for the object, and a platform for putting your shoes on display, for the concept.

While the fictional life has numerous alternative depictions on screen, it is not only there we find the tales of the Western town and its inhabitants. As mentioned before with Beyoncé, music is also exploring this fictional reality. In *McCabe & Mrs. Miller* (Altman, 1967) we find a Western unlike others, it has even been called "Anti-Western" by some. We follow



Figure 14: Homapal Alu Mirror Polished Lava Coppertone (Salmonson, 2026).

an unlikely duo with no real hero in sight (Malcolm, 1999). No matter the quality or story, one thing that stands out for me is the music score, which for me was not connected to either Westerns nor *real* country music. McCabe could be called some what of a gambler, both in cards, money and lives, and in *The Stranger Song*, Cohen sings

> But now another stranger seems
>
> To want you to ignore his dreams
>
> As though they were the burden of some other
>
> Oh, you've seen that man before
>
> His golden arm dispatching cards
>
> But now it's rusted from the elbow to the finger
>
> And he wants to trade the game he plays for shelter
>
> Yes he want to trade the game he knows for shelter (Cohen, 1967).

Before I wrote about the difficulties in describing pants-wearing as an atmosphere, for all transparency I still may have some difficulties doing just that, while these few lines, in a much longer text, put some atmosphere in to how a character might be in the Western setting, it is both in glory and decay that we find them and often these coexist at the same time. The words about the golden arm that at the same time now is rusted describes not the look but the state of McCabe, and it seems fitting that my own creation to be both and the same. With this, I was trying to find a material fitting for this purpose.

At this point in time I was also concerned about my project missing a key material of the Western town, being the use of metal so closely liked to the blazing gunslingers, but not wanting to romanticizing the symbol of a revolver. The back and top of the object, or if we call it legs would be fitting for a material with these properties, and for this construction a sheet that would be able to sweep around the back would be suitable.

Coming to this, I found Homapal Alu Mirror Polished Lava Coppertone, (HOMAPAL GmbH, 2025) which is a laminate sheet with a glueable backside, middle layer of aluminum and a metal film as a top layer. This sheet is wrapped around the construction, as well as glued onto the top of both base and doors. Inside it is also the same sheet covering the top and bottom of the shelfs. As light hits the surface, the hammered texture spreads the light as water and reflects onto the surrounding surfaces. As the low sun setting on the changing landscape of the desert, this is made to mimic the atmosphere of the traveler. Ever moving and never arriving.

The Phase III:

The Stand off:

The shoot out: Between Rescue and Kill

This next part was dedicated to creating this installation called *Between Rescue and Kill* and the fictive world of the Western town. With my created objects I want to use them as actors on display; showing the absurdity off the wild west and what material can become in this context.

To highlight the different pieces, I focused on setting the scene for the Spring Exhibition at Konstfack, making this more of a place to explore and act out in, rather than having furniture showed as furniture. As talked about before, these objects are not just furniture but actors of the theme and narrative, making it important to be able to experience being around them. With the space available it was clear that this would not be a larger installation, allowing for people to move in and around the objects with the possibilities that would provide. Instead the stage as a concept was alluring; is this not what my project have been about for all this time?

The tension is unsettling, with no one seemingly leaving the train. The three gunslingers move as silently as possible with the regard of the uneven flooring covering *Little Corner Train Station*, all pointing towards this being the last place on earth you want to be at right now. The three figures move away, turning their backs toward the outgoing train; when suddenly the freeze by the inhibitory sound from *Harmonica*, the man set out for vengeance. During the opening scene *Once Upon a Time in the West* (Leone, 1968, 00:00:00–00:13:40) sets a framework for both characters and landscape to collide and harmonize. The rugged men, shooting before asking, and all dressed to look accordingly. The same with the set and choice of *Little Corner Train Station*, where the main protagonist is introduced in a theatrical manner, placed upon this stage that is created with the flooring. Using this in my own project, my stage is not as vast but a homage to this ridged mess of planks from the railroad that is loosely put together in the film. Mdf is here sawed and painted, pretending to be both real and old, and placed as the foundation of my set. Here the window gives a glimpse from the outside not showing everything to lure the visitor inside. The chaps stand firm as the first thing you see, showing off this copper backside to the audience, and the warm light bathing the copper and further the wall with its reflections. The spotlight is set as if the sun would shine directly upon it and making the inside glimmer. You are welcomed up, to be around this cowboy, meeting its high waist.

The saloon is placed along the wall, where the street is stretching out, front after front. Being the saloon it was important

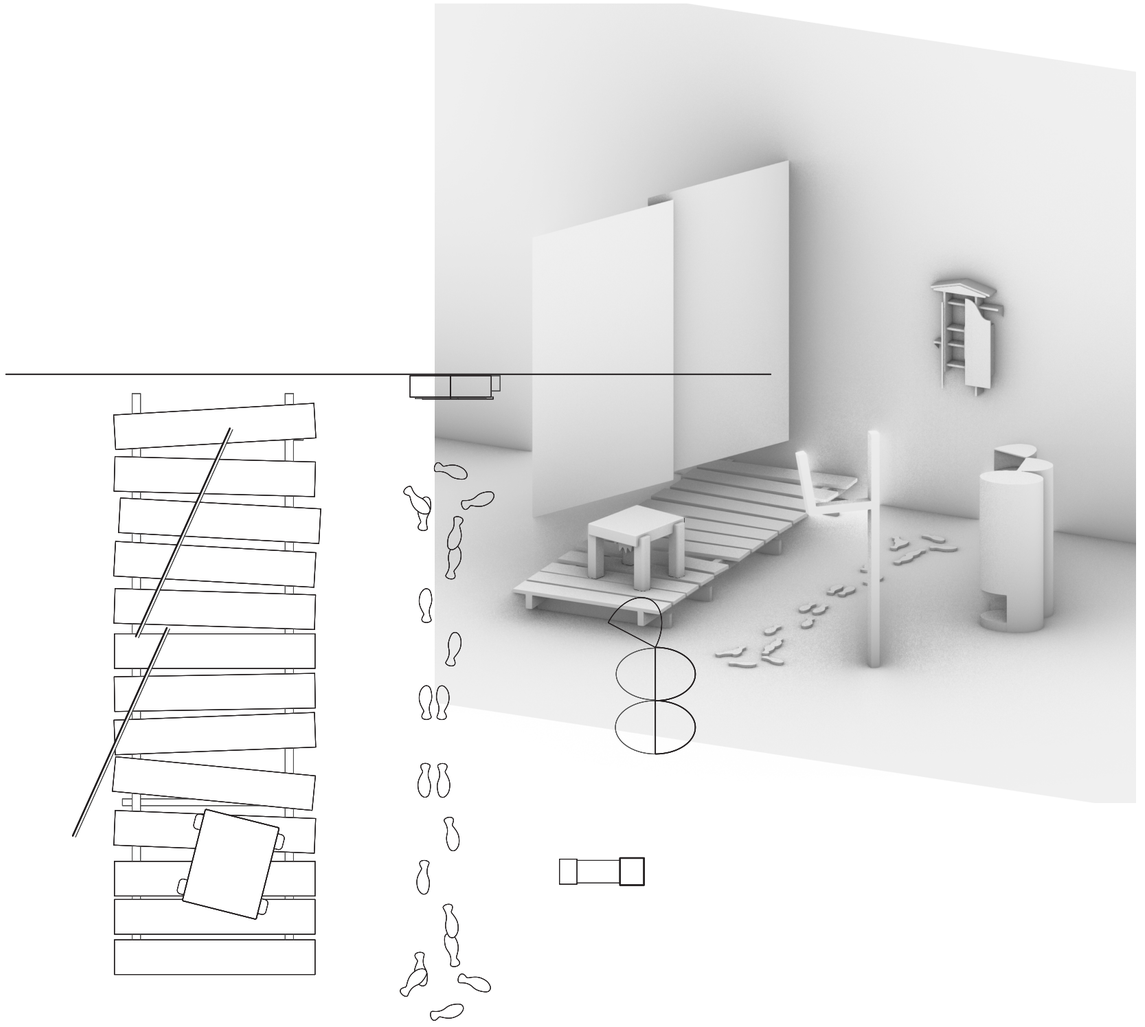


Figure 15: The Stage as sketched (Salmonsson, 2026).

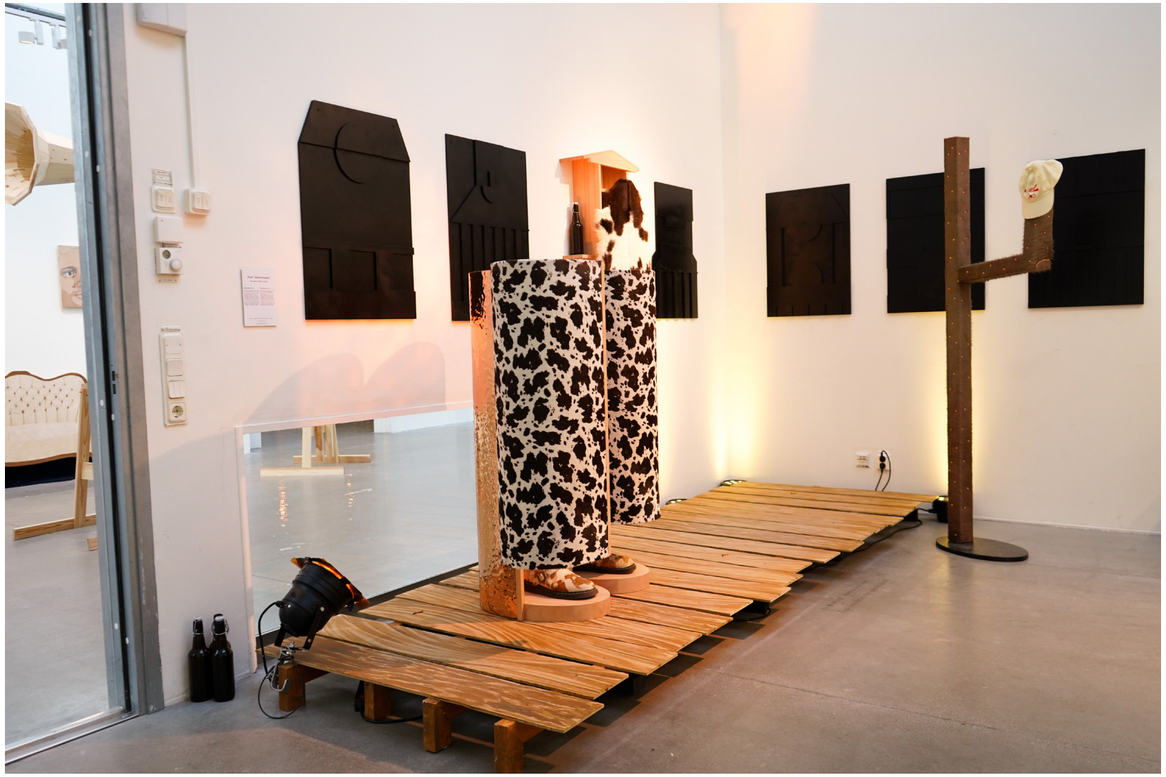


Figure 16: The set as it was presented during the spring exhibition at Konstfack 2026. The Stand off; The Shoot out: Between Rescue and Kill meaning to never expect nothing but the unexpected. (Salmonsson, 2026)

to have the presence of other buildings, being this project is about the Western town, but as the cabinet must be at the center of attention I felt that the street must be more for this atmosphere I wanted to create. Thinking back to the backed fronts from earlier I wanted to create the street from the point of view that all could be different functions within the town, and that you would not really tell which is what. The reliefs plays on this ambiguity, where on could be a home or as well be a pharmacy. The black color makes them pop out from the with wall, but at the same time fades from the observer, to render this idea of the town, more than becoming the town.

The spatial design benefits from having another piece off the stage, where we can be equals within the space before fully entering it. The cactus it perhaps the most morbid depiction of the Western elements. The cowhide becomes almost shape; playing the role of the spiky cactus. The copper rivets are soft to feel and connects the materials more together. It stands outside of the stage, in the more harsh landscape, by itself. As if it is not yet welcomed. This is not the end of the story, for when leaving town, you are always on the path to the next.

This is where my objects becomes the story to interpret, faced with a more scenographic approach, working with the spatial setting. This is to be experienced, not from the outside, still it can be experienced from a far. Like riding over the desert sand, seeing the Western town getting bigger and bigger -until you arrive and enter this fictional reality of made up narratives. Only then can this project come to life; into this new, *by you*, created reality.

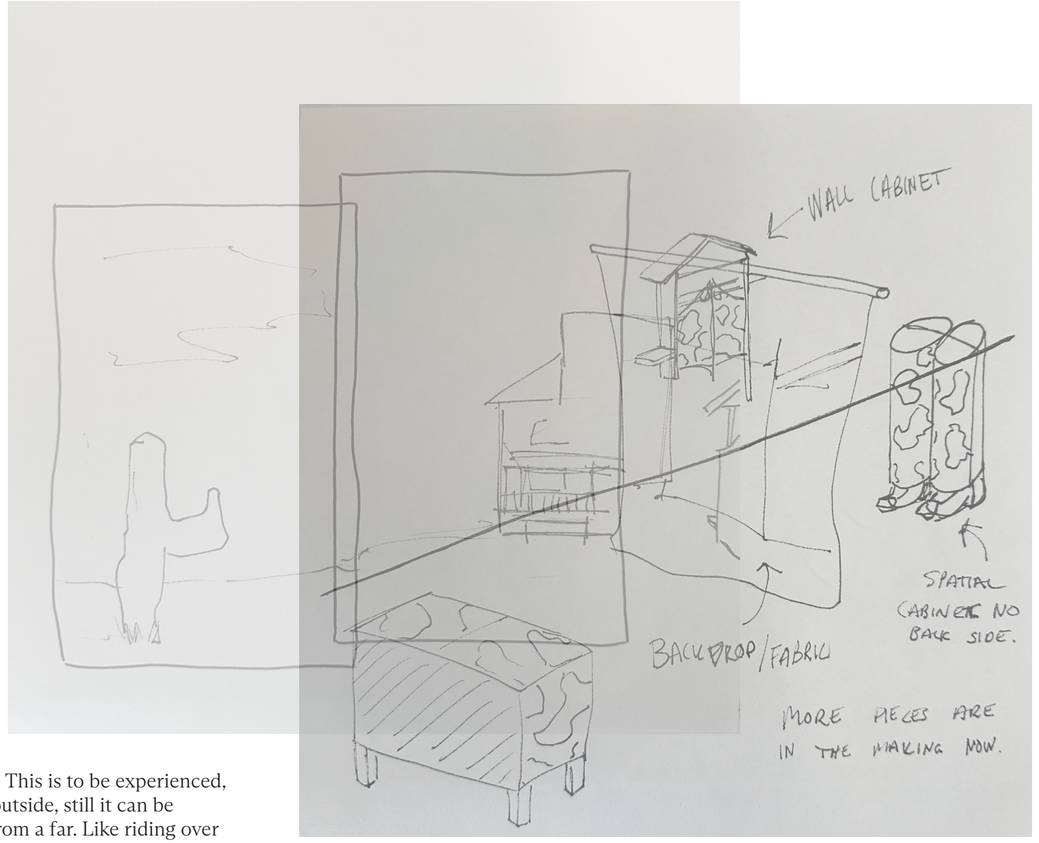


Figure 17: The Stage was first being framed with these fabrics showing the landscape vs. the town. Overlaying these scales to become the journey (Salmonsson, 2026).

As for now this project stand on the basis of cowhide and the Western town, but it is not limited to this idea. The way of working with representation, not only as a tool, but making it become the result have endless possibilities. Within interior design the start is to come up with the idea (as we discussed during in the beginning of this text) and then seeing that idea going through sketches and testing, before becoming something real. To work with this idea of the idea could help in starting the creative process. The end does not need to be as figurative and symbolic as this work, it could be much more about detail or to find the first spark. This work is also a representation about working with intuition and trusting that one decision could lead up onto next. Using fiction to create real result or using real material to end up with fiction. It is the ambiguity that creates the tension between the fiction and the real, learning how to work them both is opening up to tell all kind of stories.






Figure 18-22: Details from the spatial design during the spring exhibition at Konstfack 2026 (Salmonsson, 2026).

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List of Figures:

- Figure 1: Own sketch
- Figure 2: Own photo
- Figure 3: Leone, S. (1964) A Fistful of Dollars. [Film]. Rome: Jolly Film / Constantin Film.
- Figure 4: Ford, J. (1939) Stagecoach [Film]. Los Angeles, CA: United Artists.
- Figure 5 - 6: Tarantino, Q. (2019)Once Upon a Time in Hollywood [Film]. Los Angeles, CA: Columbia Pictures.
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- Figure 9-10: Own sketch
- Figure 11: Own photo
- Figure 12: Own sketch
- Figure 13: Own photo
- Figure 14-15: Own sketch
- Figure 16: Own photo
- Figure 17: Own sketch
- Figure 18-22: Own photo